match. I was also interested in learning more about how investing worked. I started reading books and learned what mutual funds, expense ratios, diversification, and asset allocation were. I even opened my own non-retirement brokerage account and created watchlists for individual stocks that I liked.

Of course, while I was doing all of this, I made mistakes. Tons of them, especially in my non-retirement account. I bought stocks because they were hot. I panicked when the market fell and sold too quickly, losing money as a result. I happily cashed out of stocks that had made returns, only to be deflated when I saw the taxes I had to pay (which I had no idea about) at the end of the year.

However, through trial and expensive errors, I learned how investing worked, established my comfort level with risk, and eventually was able to create clear objectives for myself as a result.

Not too long after, I discovered index funds (which we'll get into in a lot more detail in this book) and how to create an investment strategy using these funds. While I was employed at that first job, my money was invested in the limited mutual fund offerings they had. I built my contributions up to where I was not only getting the full match but also maxing out my allowable contributions. Once I left, four years later, I had well over $70,000 in that 401(k) from my contributions, my employer's match, and the gains I had earned from my investments in the stock market. I couldn't believe it! I then rolled my retirement money over into a traditional IRA and invested my money in my choice of index funds. As soon I was eligible to invest in my new employer's plan, I did that as well. This time, not only was I getting my employer's full match, but I decided to fully max out my contributions right away.

In five short years, the retirement plan I had with my new employer grew to over $100,000. Again, I was shocked, because I had really just set it and forgotten all about it. Since I began contributing to the plan almost right away, I didn't give myself a chance to get used to seeing that money included as part of my paycheck, so I didn't miss it. Instead, I was focused on my investments in my non-retirement accounts, my savings, real estate, and my side hustles. Yes, there were dips and spikes in the stock market, but